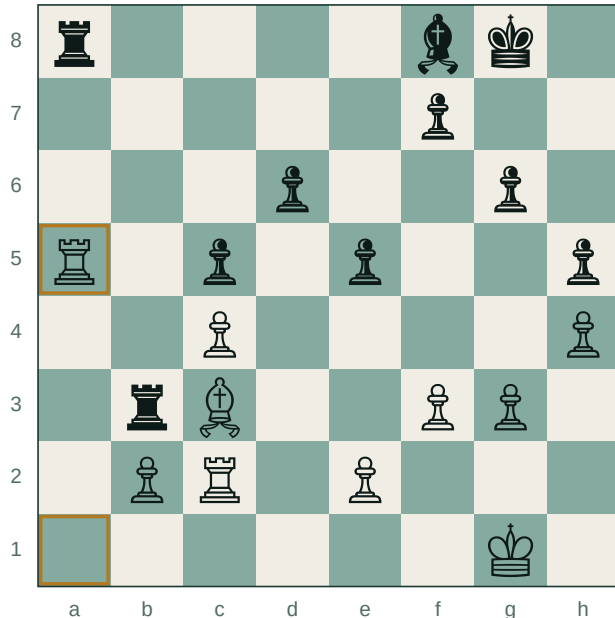


Capture the defender: Black, move 33

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 33.Rxa5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

33...Rxc3 34. Rxc3 Rxa5

33...Rxc3 The rook captures the bishop on c3. Recorded reply: **34.Rxc3**.

34...Rxa5 The rook captures the rook on a5.

At the end, nominal material is White 11 / Black 14 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +3:** the balance goes from +0 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: rook on c2. Check for tactical protection.